WEEK 2 · LESSON 8 OF 24 · HANDOUT

# Core AI Tools for Everyday Work

Study time: **about 45 minutes** (reading, video and activity)

**Your goal in this lesson:** Recognise the main categories of AI tools, choose the right tool for a task, and set up a simple free toolkit.

## You already have more than you think

You do not need expensive software to start. Most useful AI today falls into a few categories, and free versions cover most everyday needs. Tools change fast, so learn the **categories**; the names may change, the categories will not.

## The main categories

| Category | Examples | Best for |
|---|---|---|
| **General assistants** | ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, Microsoft Copilot | Writing, explaining, planning, brainstorming |
| **Search assistants** | Perplexity, AI answers in Google and Bing | Questions where you need sources and recent information |
| **Document & study tools** | NotebookLM, AI in Google Docs and Microsoft Word | Working with *your own* files: summarise, question, study |
| **Office assistants** | Copilot in Excel/PowerPoint, Gemini in Sheets/Slides | Formulas, charts, slides from your notes |
| **Design tools** | Canva AI, image generators | Posters, social-media graphics, presentations |
| **Meeting & voice tools** | Transcription and note-taking assistants | Turning meetings and lectures into notes |
| **Coding assistants** | GitHub Copilot, AI in code editors | Writing and explaining code |

## How to choose the right tool

Ask three questions:

1. **Do I need current facts with sources?** → use a search assistant, or a general assistant with web search turned on.
2. **Is the task about my own documents?** → use a document tool where you upload the files (and never upload confidential files to a tool you do not trust).
3. **Is it general writing or thinking?** → a general assistant is enough.

## Free versus paid

Free plans are usually enough to learn and for light daily use. Paid plans add newer models, larger uploads and more messages per day. **Start free.** Pay only when a tool clearly saves you more time or money than it costs. Many tools also offer discounts for students and teachers.

## Working on a phone and with slow internet

- Most general assistants have free mobile apps — useful for quick drafts and voice questions.
- Voice input can be faster than typing long prompts.
- Text answers use little data; images and video use much more.
- Save useful answers in your notes so you do not need to ask again.

## Your starter toolkit

A simple, free setup that covers almost everything in this course:

1. **One general assistant** you learn deeply (pick one and stick with it for this course).
2. **One search assistant** for questions that need sources.
3. **One document tool** for studying your own notes and readings.
4. **Canva** (or a similar tool) for visuals.

**Remember this:** Master one general assistant first, add specialised tools only when a task needs them, and always match the tool to the job.

Name: _____ Date: _____

## Activity

### Task 1

Choose your **main general assistant** and create a free account if needed.

### Task 2

Ask the same question in your general assistant **and** in a search assistant: *"What are the current requirements to register a small business in Rwanda?"*

### Task 3

Compare: Which answer gave sources? Which seemed more up to date? Check one detail on the official website (for example RDB's business registration page).

### Task 4

Write down your starter toolkit (4 tools) and what you will use each one for.

## Self-check

Think about your answers here, then take the quiz online — it is marked instantly and explains every answer.

1. Which type of tool is best when you need recent facts WITH sources?
   - A. A meeting transcription tool
   - B. A coding assistant
   - C. A search assistant
   - D. A design tool
2. You want to ask questions about your own lecture notes. Which category fits best?
   - A. Coding assistants
   - B. Document and study tools
   - C. Image generators
   - D. None — AI cannot read documents
3. What is the recommended first step for building your AI toolkit?
   - A. Master one general assistant first
   - B. Buy every paid plan
   - C. Use ten tools at once
   - D. Wait until AI is perfect
4. When does paying for an AI tool make sense?
   - A. Only if your friends pay
   - B. When it clearly saves more time or money than it costs
   - C. Never
   - D. Always, immediately
5. Why learn tool CATEGORIES rather than only tool names?
   - A. Names are hard to spell
   - B. Tools change fast, but the categories stay useful
   - C. Only categories work in Rwanda
   - D. Categories are cheaper
6. What should you NEVER upload to an AI tool you do not trust?
   - A. A public news article
   - B. A famous poem
   - C. A recipe
   - D. Confidential client or personal files

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